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Most of the talent in metros comes from smaller towns. Building your business where the talent is reduces operational costs

A DEEP TECH FUTURE

While deep-tech will not deliver instant results, it will yield long-term pay-offs that are worth the wait

▶ **ONE OF THE** primary drivers of innovation in India is its demographic advantage. With a population exceeding 1.4 billion, over 65% of whom are under the age of 35, India has a young, dynamic workforce eager to embrace new technologies and ideas. This demographic advantage has helped in the growth of the IT industry, which has transitioned from services to building an active product and SaaS ecosystem over the last decade.

India's population presents unique challenges across infrastructure, healthcare, banking and finance, manufacturing, renewable energy, agriculture, and other industries. As our challenges are unique, so should be our solutions. For example, UPI transformed and digitised the economy, addressing the issue of payments for masses and paving the way for more innovations in the fintech space. Similarly, India should continue to invest in original technologies for unique sector-specific challenges. With focused innovation, the next set of powerful global brands should come from India.

Building deep technology takes time, sometimes decades. The mindset to pursue this is diametrically opposite to the

one that seeks the high of quick growth and fast exits, or enjoys the chase of high stock value. And while deep-tech will not deliver instant results, it will yield long-term pay-offs that are worth the wait.

For anyone willing to jump into the deep end, here are a few learnings from building Zoho:

THINK BIG, START SMALL

There are problems that have a long shelf life. Take PC or mobile or construction equipment; they are long-term challenges. While you focus on the long term, have short-term goals to keep the pace of execution. When you have chosen the problem you want to solve, you have to start by learning all there is to know about that field, and thankfully, there is easy access to knowledge on the net, and communities dedicated to specific fields. As most of the learning happens while doing, instead of aiming to build a product end-to-end, start small with a component and iterate faster.

R&D IS ITERATIVE

Unlike services or production that are driven by processes, R&D requires a different mindset. It cannot be managed like a project as there are a lot more unknowns than knowns. Solutions are discovered through experiments and